

Kerala Spice Tour

07 Nights / 08 Days

Cochin - Munnar - Periyar - Alleppey - Kovalam- Trivendrum

DETAILED ITINERARY

Day 01: Arrive at Cochin Airport

Arrive at Cochin International Airport. Following customs, immigration formalities and baggage collection, our representative will meet you as you exit the arrival terminal building after which you would be transferred to your hotel.

Kochi or Cochin is a vibrant city situated on the south-west coast of the Indian peninsula in the breathtakingly scenic and prosperous state of Kerala. Its strategic importance over the centuries is underlined by the sobriquet Queen of the Arabian Sea. It is also referred to as the Gateway to Kerala. Kochi has been luring wanderers and traders for over 600 years and remains a living homage to its varied colonial past: giant fishing nets influenced by Chinese merchants, a 16th-century synagogue, ancient mosques, Portuguese houses and the crumbling residuum of the British Raj. It's a delightful place to spend some time, soak in the history, and peruse art galleries.

Upon arrival at the hotel, check-in at the hotel.

In evening, enjoy a tour on waters around the city and get a glimpse of sun setting slowly through sunset cruise in Kochi. This experience gives you a tranquil escape from the bustling metropolitan areas in Cochin. Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 02: Cochin

After Buffet Breakfast at hotel. Morning enjoy half day sightseeing tour of Cochin. The tour allows you to explore the charming fort Cochin, visit Jewish Synagogue, Dutch Palace, Jew Town, and St Francis church.

Fort Kochi is a small village located near the larger city of Kochi. There are picturesque beaches along this part of the coast line. Scattered throughout the beaches are many famous Chinese fishing nets as well as many sailing ships. The effect created by such fishing necessities is quaint and relaxing. This is the only location in the entire world outside of China where such fishing nets can be seen in use.

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The Dutch Palace is a beautiful palace that was originally built by the Portuguese. It was only during the 17th century that the Dutch took it over, modified it and then presented it to the Raja of Kochi. The main attractions here are the outstanding collection of mural paintings found inside. These murals beautifully depict scenes from the Hindu epics of Mahabharatha and Ramayana.

The Jewish synagogue built in Jew Town in 1568 is a beautiful structure. This place of worship attracts numerous visitors every year because of its impressive furnishings.

The St. Francis Church is the oldest church in India to have been built by the Europeans. The famous Portuguese trader Vasco da Gama is well known for reaching India from Europe by sea instead of by the usual overland route. The church is famous for being the initial burial place for Vasco Da Gama.

In the evening enjoy Kathakali – the traditional dance drama of Kerala it dates from the 17th century and is rooted in Hindu mythology. Kathakali is one of the most complicated, highly stylized Indian art form that is basically a Dance Drama noted for its heavy and attractive larger than life make up, elaborate costumes, detailed body movements, synchronized eye-hands movements and thematic presentation of stories with rhythmic steps. Kathakali's popularity traditionally was confined in the Palace Dance Halls, Courtyards of Nair Noble households, Temple festivals etc. till mid of 20th century when Kochi based See India Foundation started India's first regular professionally run Kathakali theatre in 1964.

Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 03: Cochin- Munnar (125 kms / 04 Hrs)

After Buffet Breakfast at hotel. Morning by surface leave for Munnar. Munnar is a haven of peace and harmony. This incredibly beautiful hill town is positioned at a height of 6000ft in the Idukki district. Munnar was a significant resort even during the British monarchs in those colonial days.

Opulent with unique species of flora and fauna, the place also has an extensive stretch of tea plantations amidst the high mountains and unspoiled valleys, giving a pleasant feeling. The scented cool air is filled with the aroma of spices. Munnar is also paradise for bird watchers as rare species of birds are found in abundance.

Rest of the day is at leisure. Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 04: Munnar-Periyar (100 Kms / 03 Hrs)

After Buffet Breakfast at hotel. Morning visit Eravikulam National Park.

The park is an ideal place for seeing the biodiversity of high elevation shola-grassland ecosystem. Visitors are taken to Rajamalai in forest department vehicles and given an opportunity to see all this. A sanctuary for the endangered mountain goat of South India, the Nilgiri Tahr (*Hemitragus hylocricus*), the Eravikulam National Park stands out for the stark beauty of its rolling grasslands and sholas, spread over 97 sq km in the Kannan devan hills. Anamudi, the highest peak (2695 m) south of Himalayas, stands majestically in the core area of the national park. The slopes of the hills abound in many kinds of rare flora which include rare terrestrial and epiphytic orchids, and beautiful wild balsams. Important fauna here are the Nilgiri Tahr, Nilgiri Langur, leopard, tiger, Indian bison, etc.

After sightseeing drive to Periyar. The Periyar Wildlife Sanctuary is situated on the banks of the Periyar Lake - an artificial lake, at Thekkady. Here the high ranges of the Western Ghats are clothed in dense evergreen, moist deciduous forests and savannah grasslands. Periyar is famous for its rich wild life and spice plantation.

Evening Later visit to Spice Plantation. Gift wrapped in lush green spice plantations, Periyar is the heartland of spices. The trip covers spice plantations such as cardamom, pepper, vanilla, clove, cinnamon, nutmeg, ayurvedic herbs etc. Over twelve varieties of spices including ginger, garlic, cardamom, vanilla, pepper, cinnamon, coffee, tea, clove and nutmeg are cultivated in Thekkady and its neighboring villages. Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 05: Periyar - Alleppey (127 Kms / 04 Hrs)

After Buffet Breakfast at hotel. Morning visit to Periyar National Park Tourists come to the National Park to view the Indian elephants in the act of ablution and playfulness by the Periyar lake. Apart from Elephants, the other animals to be seen in the Periyar sanctuary are Gaur, Wild Pigs, Sambhar, Barking Deer, Mouse Deer, Dhole or Indian Wild Dog and very rarely, a Tiger.

More than 200 species of birds have been spotted in the forests of this protected area. With the Periyar Lake in the middle, this sanctuary is a huge attraction for water birds and birds that prey on fish. The bird life here includes cormorants, kingfishers, darters, the Racket-Tailed Drongo and the Malabar hornbill. Boat cruises make the best option to check out the wilds of Periyar Sanctuary. Although it is unusual to see many animals from the boats, still you spot a family of Elephants, Wild Boar, and Sambar Deer by the water's edge. Later drive to Alleppey. On arrival, checkin Deluxe Houseboat. Later embark houseboat followed by lunch at house boat.

These houseboats or Kettuvallams as they are traditionally called were at one time the mode of transportation for man and goods. Today, these are made to cater to the discerning guests who can lay back and enjoy the gentle cruise. Cruise the backwaters from the main Vembanad Lake through the small estuaries that link small villages to the mainland. Today, these are refurbished and all modern conveniences have been added for tourists who visit this beautiful water locked region of the country. Evening is at leisure. Stay overnight at Houseboat. Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 06: Alleppey – Kovalam (158 Kms / 05 Hrs)

After Buffet Breakfast at houseboat , Disembark from houseboat and by surface drive to Kovalam. Arrive at Kovalam and transfer to the hotel. Kovalam is an internationally renowned beach with three adjacent crescent beaches. It has been a favourite haunt of tourists, especially Europeans, since the 1930s. A massive rocky promontory on the beach has created a beautiful bay of calm waters ideal for sea bathing. The leisure options at this beach are plenty and diverse. Sunbathing, swimming, herbal body toning massages, special cultural programs and catamaran cruising are some of them. The tropical sun acts so fast that one can see the faint blush of coppery tan on the skin in a matter of minutes. Evening at leisure on the Samudra Light house beach Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 07: Kovalam

After Buffet Breakfast at hotel. Early morning you may experience yoga session on the beach. Kovalam is also a getaway destination for those in search of an Ayurvedic haven away from the cacophony of city life. The experience is personal and unique. Medicinal

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plants that come fresh from the spa greenhouse are used in the treatment. Day to rejuvenate your mind, body and soul at the resort. Evening at leisure on the beach.

Stay overnight at hotel.

Day 08: Kovalam – Trivandrum Airport Drop

Morning after breakfast, drive to Trivandrum. Afternoon visit for local shopping tour & later transfer to Trivandrum Airport and connect to onward flight journey.

*******TOUR ENDS*******